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Reflections on witchcraft, danger, and modernity among the Tuareg

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Noble violence against smiths is traditionally rare because they are a protected people against whom it is not appropriate to express anger without denigrating oneself. In my early field research in the 1970s and 80s, many Tuareg described smiths as ‘like women ... also like cousins (who practise a joking relationship and also may potentially marry) ... you must not get angry at them, but (rather) joke with them’.¹¹ By the 1990s, some nobles complained that ‘in the past, smiths were afraid to commit excessive acts; but now they seek things much more aggressively, from disobedience towards an owner or patron (*ahelek*)’.

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There are escalating social tensions and even violence between some nobles and smiths. While some are becoming business partners, many are rivals in an economic system where rewards are scarce and some nobles accuse some smiths successful in tourism of ‘abandoning’ or ‘cheating’ on their traditional duties toward nobles. Accusations of sexual transgressions and pollution appear as a kind of metonymy for jealousy and wider concerns. Alleged sexual offences figure into many, though not all of these tensions. In one rural community, for example, a smith man was accused (accurately or inaccurately, I do not know) of starting a ring of prostitution and of engaging a young noblewomen in this for his own profit. Local residents reported that such organised prostitution had never existed in the countryside before, only

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in the towns. Outraged, they flogged him and ejected him from the community. The man went into exile and later became a mason in a distant region, although his relatives remained in the community and this scandal caused a rift among his supporters and detractors.

On the other hand, not all *tezma* accusations are against male smiths. Recently, a smith woman was accused of *tezma* by one of her noble patron woman's daughters. She had asked for, and been refused, sugar at this household and the daughter fell ill afterward. The smith woman cried and vehemently denied this, but her client-patron relationship with this family was broken. (Nobles may now choose to employ smiths other than those they inherited.) This breakdown was somewhat disadvantageous for the smith woman. Most rural smith women have fewer alternative sources of income or customers than smith men in the new tourist trade, where there is greater demand for men's silver and gold jewellery than women's leatherwork. Although this woman was a popular praise-singer, an important role in the countryside, she did little leatherwork and was somewhat impoverished. This smith woman had also broken a sexual taboo: she had two illegitimate children. Despite tolerance of some premarital affairs, women who give birth out of wedlock are stigmatised. Worry over spouses' infidelity is long-standing in these communities where husbands and wives are frequently separated: during men's traditional caravan expeditions,  329 refugee flight from droughts and wars, and men's more recent far-flung labour migration.

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¹¹ For additional examples and case studies involving alleged *tezma* effects from that earlier era, analysed in a different framework, see Rasmussen (1992). For in-depth analysis of longitudinal cases and histories of more recent tensions involving noble and smith women and men, see Rasmussen (1998, 2001).

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